Public backlash against IOs has grown as their influence has expanded into daily life. Populist leaders have capitalized on this discontent, portraying IOs as overreaching and out of touch. Examples are plentiful. The European Court of Human Rights faced protests after rulings on crucifixes in Italian schools[1] and prisoners' voting rights in the UK (Voeten 2020). In Costa Rica, a controversial ruling by the Inter-American Commission on Human Rights helped propel an anti-IO candidate to prominence.[2] Similarly, IMF bailouts in Argentina, Syria, and Greece; WTO rulings on controversial trade disputes; and WHO policies during the COVID-19 pandemic have sparked widespread disapproval.

In response, IOs have sought to counteract public hostility by engaging directly with domestic audiences in several ways. First, they provide tangible benefits to citizens, such as branded aid or direct support for local firms, ensuring public recognition of their contributions (Oliveros, Weltz-Shapiro, and Winters 2023). Second, IOs may present themselves as less elitist by reducing bureaucratic constraints, diversifying their leadership, or exercising judicial discretion to avoid inflammatory rulings (Voeten 2020). Third, and central to this chapter, IOs use rhetorical strategies to reshape their public image, emphasizing their alignment with ordinary citizens rather than elite interests.

We focus on rhetorical framing specifically through the lens of social media. Social media platforms provide IOs with a direct channel to engage domestic publics, counter populist narratives, and humanize their institutions. Anecdotal evidence suggests that IOs are already leveraging this approach to reshape their public images. Interviews with IMF officials, for instance, revealed deliberate efforts during the European financial crisis to frame the Fund as working for "the people." Similarly, WTO staff sought to rebrand the organization as an advocate for common citizens to sustain its relevance.[3] These efforts extend to public speeches, such as IMF managing director Kristalina Georgieva's emphasis on her humble origins to connect with everyday people: "As someone who grew up behind the Iron Curtain, I could never have expected to lead the IMF."[4] The EU, too, has launched a public relations campaign to bolster its image through the erection of "Europa Experience" exhibitions in all twenty-seven member countries that showcase how European countries are working together to better ordinary people's lives and combat global challenges.[5]